



only be achieved by winning more games.

We have to start thinking that we can do it even at the business end of tournaments. It is the direct experience that makes the player confident. One shouldn't think that 'my medal is in my range'. One should only think about winning every contest.

We now have two players in the top-25 (Sreeja Akula and Manika Batra). I hope it is consistent. If we can make the top-15 and top-10 in men's and women's events, we can start thinking a little bit bigger. We need time to achieve certain statuses to consolidate our values and individual positions.

We also need to be consistent in the team events at the Olympics. This time we made it to the top-16, the very last position. If India aims to be in the top four, we can prepare the team better. We had a short time before the Paris Olympics. We came to know only in March. We didn't have time to prepare for the doubles.

For LA, we aim to have a team that we can thoroughly prepare. In

the past, our players have struggled to qualify for the Olympics through continental and world rankings. But once we secure a team spot in the Olympics, we automatically get two players in singles, which will transform our preparations, improve our setup, and elevate our expectations as well.

With LA 2028 as the focus, do you think the time has come for a centralised training system like they have in Germany and South Korea?

There is a plan to have one in place. To regularly gather all the coaches, players and talented players from youth, sub-junior, and junior levels from across the country in one place.

Finding a place to train every time causes a little bit of inconvenience. It is better if we don't have to think about where we need to go for training. You would know where to go to get access to staff and coaches. These are things we should have by default so that we can calmly work with the players.

You are here on a two-year

Evolving as a coach: In his nearly three-decade-long coaching career, Massimo Costantini said his philosophies have evolved to put the player at the centre of things. NIGAMANTH P

contract, which can be extended to two more. What are your plans for the other major multi-discipline events, like the Asian and Commonwealth Games (CWG)?

My goal is to create the conditions that will help us become a leading country in the sport within a few years. India deserves to be in the top four because of its population, system, government, different institutions, players, coaches, the TTFI (Table Tennis Federation of India), and lots of academies.

It is a great microcosm we have to exploit. We need to develop coaches and a better system. I want to make every player and coach think that we can be right up there.

Sharath Kamal has contributed immensely to the sport. He was also the joint-flagbearer for the